

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

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BJP's Go-to Man in Bengal

Suvendu Adhikari, the most popular Opposition leader, is rallying resources to defeat the TMC and carry the momentum into 2026

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

the TMC lies with him, the 53-year-old former Trinamool heavyweight claims shrewdly, "I have my sources within them (the TMC)." If the BJP can retain its 2019 tally of 18 Lok Sabha seats or achieve a higher number, Adhikari will claim much of the credit. However, if results are below expectations, things can go south for him, and he may face attacks from bitter rivals in the state leadership, especially Bengal unit president Sukanta Majumdar and former chief Dilip Ghosh.

There is little doubt that Adhikari, who was TMC Tamluk MP from 2009 to 2016 and MLA from Kanthi (2006-2009) and is currently the two-term Nandigram MLA (from 2016)—he defeated TMC chief Mamata Banerjee in 2021—is the most popular Opposition leader in Bengal. It is apparent that the ambitious Adhikari is planning beyond 2024; his ultimate goal is to oust the TMC in the 2026 assembly polls and emerge as Bengal's top politician—one reason why he joined the BJP in 2020, after it was clear that Mamata's nephew and TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee was the CM's chosen successor.

BENGAL BJP LEADERS AND PARTY OLD-TIMERS ARE NOW DIEHARD LOYALISTS OF ADHIKARI, WHO DERIVES MUCH OF HIS CLOUT FROM HIS EQUATION WITH AMIT SHAH

"Suvenduda played a crucial role in deciding the list of candidates," says a BJP source. Seven out of the party's 42 candidates are sitting BJP MLAs and Adhikari loyalists, while at least five are TMC turncoats who joined the BJP with him or later defected. In deciding candidates in many other seats, Adhikari had his way with the party's parliamentary board. "If these candidates win, Suvenduda's dominance in the state unit will be cemented. But if that doesn't happen, things can go southward for him," says the source.

Much of Adhikari's clout in the fragmented Bengal BJP unit derives from his equation with Union home minister Amit Shah. "We'll win all the six seats that went to the polls in the first two phases," Adhikari tells INDIA TODAY. "Of the four in the third phase, we will win at least one. The contest is bipolar. In most seats, it is between us and the TMC. Even those walking in Left-Congress rallies will vote for us."

However, Adhikari is currently accused of political subterfuge concerning a top poll plank of the BJP—the alleged atrocities committed against women by TMC leaders in Sandeshkhali. Recently, the TMC released a series of 'sting operation' videos where local BJP workers purportedly 'admit' that the whole incident was stage managed by Adhikari. The allegation goes that 72 women were paid Rs 2,000 each to lodge complaints of sexual assault and land-grabbing, the complainants made to sign blank papers. Adhikari has spiritedly claimed that the videos were doctored and must be tested by forensic experts.

But first, Adhikari has to secure the two LS seats—Kanthi and Tamluk—in his home district, Purba Medinipur, where his family wields massive influence. Sisir Adhikari, Suvendu's father, and his brother Dibyendu are the outgoing TMC MPs for Kanthi and Tamluk, respectively, though the party has fielded other candidates this time. They will be facing Suvendu's youngest brother Soumendu, the BJP candidate from Kanthi, and former justice Abhijit Ganguly, who is the candidate in Tamluk.

Adhikari is now undisputedly the tallest BJP leader in Bengal. But only the imprimatur of a good score in the polls will cement that position. ■